

TOPIC 3: ENVIRONMENTAL DEGRADATION – FLOODING

1. Meaning of Flooding

Flooding is the overflow of water onto land that is normally dry. It occurs when rivers, lakes or drains cannot hold the volume of water from heavy rainfall or other sources, so the water spreads over surrounding areas.

2. Causes of Flooding

- Heavy and prolonged rainfall
- Overflow of rivers and dams
- Blocked drainage systems and gutters (often by refuse)
- Deforestation (trees reduce runoff; without them water flows faster)
- Building on flood plains and wetlands
- Poor urban planning and inadequate drainage
- Climate change leading to more intense rainstorms
- Release of water from dams

3. Effects of Flooding on the Environment and Human Life

- Destruction of houses, roads, bridges and farmland
- Loss of human lives and livestock
- Displacement of people (internally displaced persons)
- Contamination of water sources → water-borne diseases (cholera, typhoid)
- Loss of crops and food shortage
- Soil erosion and deposition of sand/silt on farmlands
- Disruption of schools, markets and economic activities
- Spread of mosquitoes and other disease vectors

4. Flood Control Measures

- Construction and regular clearing of drainage channels
- Building of dams, embankments and levees
- Afforestation and protection of wetlands
- Proper urban planning – avoid building on flood plains
- Early warning systems and weather forecasts
- Community clean-up of gutters and refuse
- Contour farming and terracing to reduce runoff
- Public education on flood risks and preparedness

5. Community Roles in Flood Prevention

- Dispose of refuse properly; do not dump waste in drains.
- Participate in community drainage-clearing exercises.
- Plant trees and protect existing vegetation.
- Report blocked drains and illegal structures to authorities.
- Support government flood-control projects.
- Prepare emergency plans and move to higher ground when warned.

6. Summary

Flooding is the overflow of water onto dry land. It is caused by heavy rain, blocked drains, deforestation and poor planning. Effects include loss of life, property and health problems. Control requires good drainage, tree planting, proper planning and active community participation.

End of Topic 3 – Flooding